Exhibition planning discussion packet

17 October 2026 | v21.2 | Not a submission package

The following pages are prepared drafts. Actual eligible institution, appointments, signed letters, original-source identifiers, rights and approved costs remain required. Do not attach this combined file to an NEH application.

NEH Public Humanities Projects: submission gates

Status: prepared institutional discussion draft; not submission-ready. Verified 17 October 2026.

Target: Exhibitions: Planning, temporary single-site exhibition. Draft request $25,920; planning ceiling $75,000, up to 24 months; no required cost share. Deadline 16 December 2026, 11:59 p.m. Eastern. Proposed draft period 1 November 2027–31 October 2028. The October 2026 NOFO says earliest start 1 November 2027; the program web page says 1 October. Resolve with program staff before filing. No message has been sent.

Eligible applicant must be a qualifying U.S. nonprofit, public/nonprofit accredited higher education institution, state/local government or federally recognized tribal government. Individuals and for-profits are ineligible. The NOFO expressly excludes fiscal sponsors applying for an ineligible organization and fiscal agent/sponsor fees. The institution must lead its own substantive project. An external researcher can have a scoped institutional role; this is not eligibility by pass-through.

Component	Prepared here	Still required before submission
narrative.pdf	Draft under required headings, AI acknowledgment; below 15-page limit	Real eligible institution/team, consulted scholarship, audience basis and final reviewed wording
workplan.pdf	12-month staged draft	Named responsibilities, approved dates matching forms
resumes.pdf	Intake template only	Actual reviewed team list and résumés; suggested 2 pages each
letters.pdf	Unsent templates only	Signed, dated commitments from outside scholars and partners/ consultants as applicable
bibliography.pdf	Selected draft, suggested 2-page limit	Complete original source identifiers and works actually used
Budget + budget justification	Arithmetic-checked estimated direct costs; budget-justification.pdf	Applicant category mapping, employee fringe, rates/quotes, indirect decision and final R&R Budget
Federal forms	Checklist only	SF-424 Short Organizational; NEH supplementary cover; performance site form; R&R Budget; attachments form; conditional lobbying/debt/indirect/ subrecipient documents
Registration / authorization	Not represented	Active SAM/UEI, Grants.gov access and institutional authorized submission

Component	Prepared here	Still required before submission
Rights / collection access	Catalog flags gaps	Permissions or replacements for selected materials; documented custody and access

Do not add a cover/summary/table of contents to the NEH narrative. Do not attach this combined discussion packet or unrequested supporting material to the application: the NOFO rejects extra application elements. Walkthrough and exhibition object-list attachments are required for Implementation, not this Planning request. Use conditional attachments only when applicable. Review current opportunity forms and the General Application Guide before authorized filing; this is not a certification of all federal requirements.

Official sources: Program page; October 2026 NOFO, especially pages 1, 3–8 and 9–14; opportunity listing. Recheck changes before submission. The narrative retains AI acknowledgment because the NOFO requires acknowledgment when AI-generated text is inserted.

Decision rule: pursue the December cycle only if a qualified institution adopts the project in time to complete its own review. Otherwise preserve this packet for a later verified opportunity; do not invent partners, inflate a budget, or assume a future deadline.

Nature of the request

An eligible institution, still to be confirmed, would request **$25,920 in Exhibitions: Planning** support for a temporary, single-site exhibition, Records, Memory, and Civilian Violence: The Horner Family in Civil War Arkansas. This 12-month planning project would develop and test a source-based exhibition concept for general public audiences in Johnson County, Arkansas. Its central question is how government records, memorials and later family narratives illuminate different parts of civilian wartime experience. The intended products are a scholarly interpretive framework, a checked object/source list, accessible sample labels, a design concept, an audience-testing report and a costed implementation plan. This is an institutional discussion draft, not a completed application.[1]

Humanities content

The project would examine three related ideas. First, government records describe people through administrative purposes: a land patent records a transfer of specified tracts, while a census reports household and property information. The corrected 1860 Mulberry Township image lists Spencer Horner and Permelia; the 1857 patent lists four tracts. Neither explains the later attackers' motives. Displaying record and inference side by side would help visitors practice close reading rather than mistake property valuations for evidence of intent.

Second, memories of violence develop through family transmission and public commemoration. A marker reading gives William Riley Horner's death as 10 August 1864 and attributes responsibility to parties known to his family. A later account attributed to 1942 describes an attack and reprisals. Visitors would ask what each source preserves, when it was made, and which questions remain beyond it. The project would neither present a reprisal count as a proved casualty total nor infer official refusal to investigate from missing records.

Third, uncertainty can be made legible without abandoning historical interpretation. The archive's prior census misidentification and reversed patent aliquot demonstrate why provenance and correction matter. A label could show a claim being narrowed as a source is checked. The exhibition would connect this local example to the broader history of irregular warfare and civilian protection. Proposed contextual reading includes Daniel E. Sutherland's A Savage Conflict (2009) and Thomas A. DeBlack's With Fire and Sword (2003). Publisher listings were checked, but full texts and relevant page-level arguments have not been integrated in this draft. Appointed outside scholars must develop and document that contextual argument before submission. No scholarly endorsement is claimed.

Project formats

The envisioned exhibition would have four compact sections: household and land; wartime loss; family memory and memorials; and the historian’s evidence desk. A census facsimile with a readable partial transcription would introduce administrative evidence. A patent detail would let visitors compare the four tract descriptions without suggesting a verified modern house site. A short, attributed family-account paraphrase and a permitted marker image would invite comparison of document dates, event dates and memorial dates. The evidence desk would ask visitors to choose a next record and explain what it could resolve.

Large-print labels, image descriptions, seated reading access and a printable text companion would be tested during planning. No graphic injury detail is necessary to the interpretive questions. Visitors could engage the land/census comparison independently of the killing narrative. A modest website companion and educator sheets would extend access to the public exhibition; an online archive or school lesson alone is not the proposed NEH primary format. Exact venue, available floor area, objects and installation dates await institutional decisions and are not invented here. Planning would develop, rather than claim completion of, a final exhibition.

Project resources

The existing archive contains a patent image, a corrected census household image, compared-copy GLO survey notes, a marker photograph, a pension payment ledger, published family-account excerpts and research summaries. The v21 source catalog distinguishes examined images from unverified original-record claims. It also corrects a mislabeled cemetery gallery and withdraws unsupported modern parcel conclusions. These resources provide a starting collection for interpretation, not a fully authenticated exhibition object list.

For each proposed object, the institution would record custody, original collection and identifier, date, maker, reliable transcription, rights, display format and relevance to a label. Federal record images and privately made photographs would receive separate rights assessments. A marker image or family manuscript would enter exhibition production only after permission or an appropriate rights determination. Missing originals would be sought only where needed for the exhibition’s interpretive questions. The plan does not fund an open-ended genealogy search or certify the original service and pension files through summaries.

Project history

Daniel Bret Lingar has assembled a descendant-led website and dossier about the Horner family. On 17 October 2026, a source and funding review identified image substitutions, unsupported source-to-claim links, spatial conflicts and overly broad grant language. This planning draft builds on a new concise reading edition, source catalog and correction register. It does not bill the already prepared website or bibliography as future initial creation. Proposed new work is

independent scholarly interpretation, provenance and rights completion for selected objects, audience testing, accessible design and an implementation plan. A comparison with existing local exhibitions and collections is still required; priority or uniqueness is not asserted.

Audience, marketing, and promotion

The proposed primary audience is the general public in Johnson County, including adults interested in regional history and visitors who may not pursue genealogy. No audience survey, attendance history, mailing-list size, venue commitment or partner reach is established in this draft. A provisional planning target is two small prototype sessions totaling 20–30 adult participants, with recruitment and capacity to be agreed by the institutional host. This is an estimated testing sample, not an exhibition attendance forecast. The institution would document recruitment channels, accessibility requests and attendance without presuming a demographic profile. Any later public attendance estimate must derive from the confirmed venue’s actual comparable-program records. Schools are a companion audience, not the basis of the proposed NEH public-format eligibility.

Project evaluation

Prototype visitors would compare two sources, distinguish a directly stated fact from an inference, and identify a useful next record. The evaluation consultant would gather anonymous responses, observe confusing labels and record image-reading or access barriers. A proposed design target is that at least 75% of responding visitors can correctly distinguish the census reference date of 1 June 1860 from the enumeration date of 20 June 1860 after using the display. This is not a measured result. The evaluation report would include participant count, response count, question wording, anonymized totals, limitations and the revisions made. Small convenience samples would inform design rather than support population-wide claims. No personal trauma disclosure or student information is required.

Organizational profile

Required completion before submission: identify the eligible applicant by legal name, status, mission, location, annual operating budget, staff capacity and relevant public audience/visitor figures, with documentary support. No institution is named as a committed applicant. The recipient must own the project substantively through decisions, collections/permissions management, scholarly direction, public access and financial administration. The 2026 NEH notice excludes individuals and for-profit applicants and disallows a fiscal sponsor applying on behalf of an ineligible organization. A pass-through arrangement for Daniel Lingar or Capitol Contracts LLC would not solve eligibility. Each collaborating organization must supply a confirmed role and authorized commitment; no implied endorsement should be inferred from a prospect list.

Project team

The proposed roles are an applicant project director, a source researcher/descendant collaborator, a coordinator, an exhibition designer, an accessibility reviewer and an evaluation consultant. Daniel Lingar is proposed for the source-research role, subject to an approved scope and written institutional relationship; his descendant perspective does not substitute for independent historical review. No person’s credentials, résumé, available hours or agreement is invented. The applicant must name qualified staff, document their responsibilities and approve procurement or contracting arrangements before submission. Proposed labor quantities and rates remain estimates.

Humanities scholars and consultants

Two outside historians are proposed: one with Arkansas Civil War/irregular warfare expertise and one with public history, memory or documentary interpretation expertise. Each would be involved across source selection, interpretive framing, label review, prototype discussion and final planning review, with 40 estimated hours per scholar. An education consultant would review the companion source sheets. The institution must recruit named qualified advisers, consult their work and obtain signed, dated letters describing scope, availability and agreed compensation before applying. No scholar has accepted this role in this draft. The bibliography is a proposed reading framework, not evidence of those consultations.

[1] This draft contains AI-generated text prepared with ChatGPT/Codex and requires human source checking, revision and institutional approval. Retain an appropriate acknowledgment for any AI-generated text used in an NEH proposal, as required by the 2026 notice. The applicant must replace all unconfirmed organizational, team, rights, audience and cost assumptions before submission.

Work plan: Exhibitions Planning

Draft period: 1 November 2027–31 October 2028. All roles unappointed; applicant must confirm. These are proposed award-period activities, not a restart of work already completed. The NOFO start window begins 1 November 2027; the program page lists 1 October. Use the NOFO for this draft and resolve the discrepancy with NEH before filing.

Period	Activity and dependency	Responsible role	Reviewable output
Months 1–2	Confirm interpretive questions; select resources from v21 catalog; scholars review regional context	Institutional director; two outside historians; researcher	Approved interpretive brief and selected-source register
Months 2–4	Verify selected originals, transcriptions and rights; resolve only questions needed for labels	Researcher; historians; institutional rights lead	Object/source list with citations, permissions status and explicit exclusions
Months 4–6	Draft four-section visitor sequence; prototype labels and image alternatives	Designer; historians; accessibility reviewer	Design concept, sample labels, access review
Months 7–8	Test with two small adult groups after host/recruitment agreement	Evaluation consultant; host; coordinator	Anonymized feedback, counts and interpretation findings
Months 9–10	Revise content and design from test; companion educator review	Historians; designer; education consultant	Revised concept, corrected labels and companion sheets
Months 11–12	Define implementation scope, production costs, rights remaining and stewardship	Institutional director; coordinator; designer	Final planning report, costed implementation plan and maintenance responsibilities

The institutional director approves each stage before the next uses it. Unresolved source or permission problems lead to an attributed alternative or exclusion, not an unsupported label. No final exhibition fabrication or opening is claimed within this planning request.

Selected bibliography for exhibition planning

Draft: source identifiers and publication details must be completed where marked.

U.S. Census, 1860, Schedule 1, Mulberry Township, Johnson County, Arkansas, dwelling 698 / family 699, lines 1–7 (Spencer Horner household). Owner-supplied export, page 1; stamped 1029. Original microfilm/provider identifier not yet reconciled. Source S01.

United States, Fayetteville Land Office, Patent 19B, 1 April 1857, Spencer Horner, assignee. Repository image; BLM/GLO accession to be completed. Source S02.

William Riley Horner grave marker, photograph in Horner Archive. Marker records death 10 August 1864; installation date and photographer unknown. Permission/custody to be completed. Source S03.

Horner, Eva, attributed recorder. Family history attributed to 1942; published excerpts in Horner Archive. Complete manuscript, authorship/date and transmission chain unverified. Source S04.

Johnson County pension payment ledger, page 283, columns 1910–1915, Henry Stewart entry. Full archive/catalog citation pending. Source S05.

Arkansas Commissioner of State Lands. Compared-copy field notes, T12N R24W, Book 913A, bundle BD0164; selected section-line notes, 1843–1844 headings. Continued-entry dating remains open. Source S06.

DeBlack, Thomas A. With Fire and Sword: Arkansas, 1861–1874. Fayetteville: University of Arkansas Press, 2003. Proposed contextual scholarship; full-text/page-level integration pending.

Sutherland, Daniel E. A Savage Conflict: The Decisive Role of Guerrillas in the American Civil War. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2009. Proposed contextual scholarship; full-text/page-level integration pending.

Pension and military summaries (S07) remain retrieval leads rather than independently checked original-record bibliography entries. Scholars must add the works actually used in their interpretation and replace provisional identifiers before filing.

Exhibition planning budget | v21.0 | 17 October 2026

Illustrative 12-month direct-cost request: $25,920. No award, approved rates, vendor quotes or applicant budget approval are represented. This replaces the earlier broad startup scenarios. All costs are prospective, tied to exhibition planning, and subject to allowability and applicant review. Prior website, bibliography and source-acquisition work is not billed again as a future deliverable.

Cost / role	Units	Rate	Amount	Basis
Applicant project director	40 hours	$50.00	$2,000.00	Institutional oversight, decisions and final review; provisional salary basis, fringe to be calculated by applicant
Source researcher / descendant collaborator	120 hours	$35.00	$4,200.00	Source register, provenance checks and record comparison; proposed role for Daniel Lingar subject to written agreement
Project coordination	100 hours	$35.00	$3,500.00	Schedule, permissions log, meetings and document control; assigned by applicant
Outside humanities historians	80 hours	$85.00	$6,800.00	Two independent historians, 40 hours each; topic and source review, not confirmed appointments
Education consultant	24 hours	$55.00	$1,320.00	Review companion source sheets and interpretation for clarity; no classroom outcomes assumed
Exhibition designer	60 hours	$50.00	$3,000.00	Concept layout and accessible label prototype, not fabrication
Accessibility reviewer	24 hours	$65.00	$1,560.00	Plain-language, image alternatives, contrast and print/digital access review
Evaluation consultant	24 hours	$50.00	$1,200.00	Public prototype testing design, analysis and revision memo
Record digitization	120 pages	$2.00	$240.00	Estimated scanning units, not a repository quote
Prototype printing	100 sets	$4.00	$400.00	Low-volume test copies, not final exhibition production
Consultation room rental	2 sessions	$250.00	$500.00	Only if a paid room is necessary; replace with actual quote or zero if provided
Local travel	8 trips	$50.00	$400.00	Per-trip planning estimate, not a verified mileage rate; use applicant policy and actual distance
Repository reproduction fees	10 orders	$40.00	$400.00	Allowance by estimated order, not a NARA price quote; allocate only to exhibition-related records
Prototype accessible transcription	20 units	$20.00	$400.00	Estimated short source/label units; avoid double counting researcher work

Direct costs: $25,920.00. Indirect costs: $0 in this draft. Proposed federal request: $25,920.00. Proposed cost share: $0. The selected NEH program does not require cost sharing. Zero indirect is an explicit draft assumption, not a statement that the applicant cannot claim a permitted rate. No contingency, fiscal sponsor/agent fee, grant-writing fee, fundraising, land purchase or final fabrication is included. Budget must change if roles, rates, fringe, travel, rights or the institution’s indirect treatment change.

Budget justification and evidence to collect

The applicant director directs the institution’s own exhibition project, rather than serving as a pass-through. The researcher prepares evidence for interpretation; coordination manages the actual planning work. The outside historians develop context and critique labels throughout. Design, accessibility and evaluation produce a testable exhibition concept and documented revision, not a promise of completed exhibition installation.

No named consultant has agreed to these rates or appointments. Collect dated scope/rate letters for each consultant, institutional salary/fringe calculations for employee effort, price estimates for printing/reproductions, and a travel basis consistent with policy. Attach this evidence to the internal working budget; do not invent quotations. Classify employee, contractor and any subrecipient by the actual relationship. The institution must map the rows to the Research and Related Budget categories and provide any required subrecipient budget or indirect agreement.

Daniel Lingar or Capitol Contracts LLC may be considered for a properly scoped, approved role; neither is represented as an eligible NEH applicant. A grant is not an automatic payment entitlement. Any agreement must set deliverables, hours/rate or fee, rights, conflict review, invoice requirements and who accepts the work. The applicant must retain substantive authority. The same hours cannot be charged twice under research and coordination.

Suggested invoice evidence: date; task; source/deliverable ID; hours; approved rate; amount; acceptance by institutional lead. Hold a separate permissions/fee ledger. Revise the request from confirmed costs before any submission.

Commitment templates and factual intake

Unsent working templates. These are not letters of support, institutional agreements, résumés or evidence of appointments. Replace bracketed fields only with verified information, have each signer review their own commitments, and obtain signed, dated originals. Do not upload these blanks as letters.pdf.

Applicant institution: facts and authorization

Legal name / eligibility evidence / UEI / active SAM registration / authorized Grants.gov representative: [complete]. Mission, operating budget, actual comparable attendance, staff availability and relevant collection/venue: [document]. Named project director and grant administrator: [confirm distinct responsibilities]. Decision-making, rights control, record stewardship, public access and financial accountability: [specify]. Relationship with external director or researcher: [written agreement]. Proposed budget and indirect/fringe treatment: [approve]. Institution’s own substantive exhibition purpose: [explain].

Outside scholar letter: proposed language to customize

To the institutional project director: I, [name, title, affiliation], agree to serve as an outside humanities adviser for [institution]’s proposed exhibition-planning project, [title], during [dates], conditional on [award and any other conditions]. My relevant expertise and publications are [accurate details]. I will contribute [specific activities] across source selection, framing, prototype review and final planning. My expected effort is [hours], with [agreed compensation/expense basis]. I have reviewed [materials actually reviewed] and offer the following substantive contribution: [scholar’s own assessment]. [Signature and date].

Venue / public testing partner letter

Authorized organization and signer: [complete]. Agree to [specific space, dates or availability window, recruitment tasks, accessible arrangements, capacity, cost/in-kind contribution and supervision]. Describe prior relationship only if documented. State any conditions. This commitment is for [planning tests / later exhibition], not both by implication. [Signature and date].

Researcher or consultant scope

Person or legal business / qualifications supported by résumé: [complete]. Deliverables and acceptance criteria: [source IDs, labels, hours, due dates]. Rate or fixed fee and maximum amount: [agreed]. Invoice and approval process: [complete]. Reproduction rights and licenses: [complete]. Conflicts/procurement classification: [institutional determination]. No guarantee of payment exists without an executed agreement and available funds.

Rights request checklist

Source title and creator; custodian; exact image/text/version; proposed display, online and print uses; term/territory; credit; fee; restrictions; authorized response. Do not infer permission from possession of a scan or a website footer. Retain correspondence and the permission itself.

Résumé intake

For each actual team member: full name/title/affiliation, relevant training, selected publications/projects, role and availability. Obtain their reviewed résumé. Suggested NEH length is two pages per person; no credentials were generated for this packet.